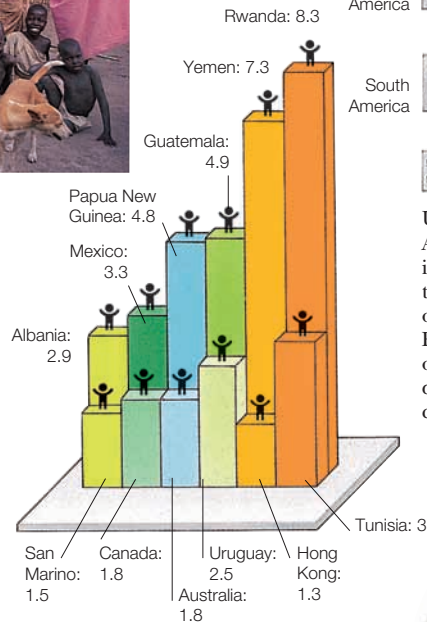




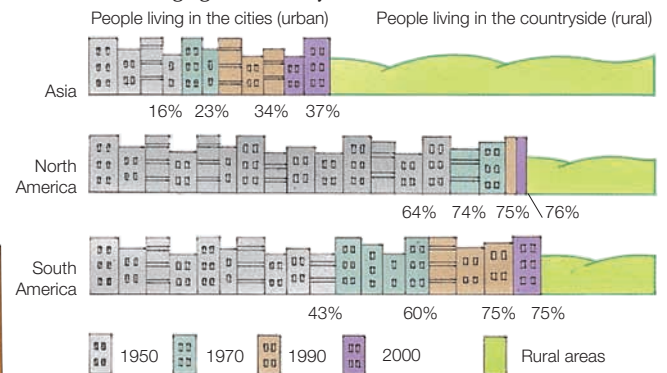
Highest and lowest birth rates within each continent



BIRTH AND DEATH

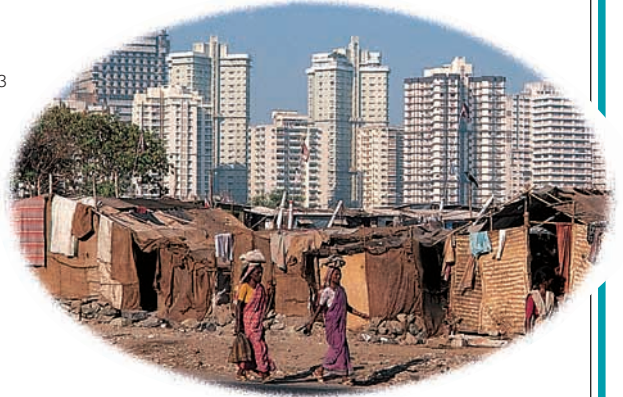
The number of babies a woman has varies from one country to another. In the Sudan, above, the birth rate is high, with an average of 4.9 babies per mother. Better health care, even in the poorer countries of the world, means that fewer babies now die of hunger or disease, and fewer women die in childbirth. In wealthy countries, such as Canada, the birth rate is low because people can choose to have small families. Advances in medical knowledge also mean that people are living longer.

Percentage growth of city dwellers



URBAN GROWTH

At the start of the 20th century, only one in ten people lived in a city. The vast majority lived in rural areas and worked on the land. Today, about half the world's population consists of city dwellers. There are various reasons for this growth. For example, in South America people have been pushed out of the countryside by poverty and loss of land and are drawn to the cities in search of work. By 2020, if the growth continues, almost half of all people will live in a city.



CITY SLUMS

One effect of the move of large numbers of people from the countryside to the cities is overcrowding. There are simply not enough houses and resources to go around. In many large cities, such as Mumbai (Bombay), India, this has led to the growth of sprawling shanty towns on the edges of cities. Conditions in these city slums are often unhygienic. Families survive in crowded homes made of makeshift materials, often with no electricity or running water.



WORLD'S BIGGEST CITIES IN 1950	
New York, US	12,300,000
London, UK	8,700,000
Tokyo, Japan	6,700,000
Paris, France	5,400,000
Shanghai, China	5,300,000

WORLD'S BIGGEST CITIES IN 2005	
Tokyo, Japan	34,200,000
Mexico City, Mexico	22,800,000
Seoul, South Korea	22,300,000
New York, USA	21,900,000
São Paulo, Brazil	20,200,000

SUPER CITIES

Before the 19th century, cities with more than a million people were rare. In the last 100 years, however, the number of large cities has grown dramatically. Today, several cities, such as Tokyo, already have populations of more than 20 million. This means that some cities have more people than some entire countries do, such as New Zealand or Sweden. Large cities often suffer from pollution, caused by car exhausts, factory emissions, and domestic waste.

LOOKING TO THE FUTURE

Although world population growth is showing signs of slowing, numbers are still rising quickly, especially in developing countries. To encourage people to have fewer children, programs have been set up to teach women about family planning and health care so that they have more control over the size and health of their families. Today, almost half the married women in the developing world report that they or their partner use birth control, compared with less than a quarter in 1980.

This doctor is writing out a prescription for contraceptives, now used by 43 percent of the women in Zimbabwe.

